

2 FERTILIZATION

A single sperm penetrates the outer layers of the egg to fertilize it, while it is in the fallopian tube. The 23 chromosomes (which contain DNA, the genetic information needed for the development of a cell) in the sperm join with the 23 in the egg. Together these 46 chromosomes create a blueprint that makes your baby unique.

The fertilized egg, now called a zygote, divides into two identical cells. Within hours, the zygote divides multiple times into a microscopic ball of cells (morula) as it heads toward the uterus.

Fallopian tube

Path of egg

Zygote Once fertilized, the egg is known as a zygote

Morula Around three to four days after fertilization, a ball of around 16 cells heads toward the uterus

Fimbriae Fingerlike projections sweep the egg into the fallopian tube

Ovary A mature egg is released from the ovary

Blastocyst By the time it implants in the uterus, about a week after fertilization, what was a single cell is now a ball of up to 100 cells

Uterus At this stage the uterus is the size of a plum, but will expand as your developing baby grows

3 IMPLANTATION

About a week after fertilization, the ball of cells, now known as a blastocyst, implants itself in the lining of the uterus. The blastocyst has an outer layer of cells, which will develop into the placenta, and an inner mass of cells that will become the embryo.

Once implanted, the blastocyst begins to secrete the pregnancy hormone hCG, which helps to maintain the thick lining of the uterus and prevents it from shedding (your monthly period). This is the hormone that can be detected in your urine when you take a pregnancy test.

1 OVULATION

The ovaries typically alternate in releasing an egg during each monthly cycle, so ovulation takes place from just one ovary. One—or occasionally more than one—fully mature egg is released from an ovary and is wafted into a nearby fallopian tube.

Once the egg begins its journey, the ovaries produce the hormone progesterone, which causes the uterine lining to thicken and ripen in anticipation of a possible pregnancy. It also produces the nutrients necessary to support a developing embryo, and causes the breast lobules (milk glands) to swell.

FROM OVULATION
TO IMPLANTATION

